

How Everyday Living Creates Disease

Asātmya-indriyārtha-samyoga - Misuse of the senses

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कालबुद्धीन्द्रियार्थानां योगो मिथ्या न चाति च। द्वायाश्रयाणां व्याधीनां त्रिविधो हेतुसंग्रहः ॥

--- चरकसंहिता सूत्रस्थान (9.५४)

The causes of the diseases relating to both (mind and body) are three-fold: wrong utilisation, non-utilisation and excessive utilisation of time, mental faculties and objects of sense organs.

Where Does Disease Begin?

When we think of disease, we usually imagine something going wrong inside an organ—a stomach problem, a lung problem, or a heart problem. We rarely consider that disease may begin much earlier, long before any organ starts to complain. Āyurveda offers a very different starting point. It suggests that many diseases originate not in organs, but in how we live every day: how we see, hear, eat, sleep, think, and continuously stimulate ourselves.

From an Āyurvedic perspective, the senses are not passive receivers of information. They are active gateways through which the external world enters the body and the mind. What we repeatedly see, hear, taste, touch, and mentally dwell upon shapes our internal state. Health or disease begins with how wisely-or unwisely-these gateways are used. Āyurveda uses the term *Asātmendriyārtha samyoga* to describe this idea. In simple language, it refers to the inappropriate, excessive, deficient, or unnatural use of the senses. This misuse is rarely dramatic. Most of the time, it appears very ordinary and socially accepted. Eating when not hungry, sleeping far later than the body naturally prefers, consuming food while distracted, living with constant noise, or spending long hours in front of screens all fall under the everyday misuse of the senses.

The Senses and the Modern World

Modern life has also introduced a subtler and more continuous form of sensory misuse through constant exposure to stimulating visual scenes and sounds. Rapidly changing images, high-intensity audio, emotionally charged content, and endlessly scrolling feeds can keep the senses in a state of alertness. Even when the body is physically resting, the senses and the mind may remain engaged. Āyurveda recognizes that the senses, like muscles, require periods of genuine rest. When stimulation becomes uninterrupted, the mind may grow restless, sleep may become shallow, digestion may become irregular, and stress may quietly accumulate. Hence, Caraka Saṃhitā identifies excessive or inappropriate engagement with the objects of the senses as one among the causes of disease. This does not mean that all entertainment is inherently harmful. Entertainment can also promote relaxation, joy, harmony, and balance. The concern arises when stimulation becomes excessive, inappropriate, or continuous, rather than when it is simply enjoyable.

Āyurveda further observes that sensory misuse is not limited to external exposure alone. Mental engagement itself acts as a form of sensory stimulation. Repeatedly dwelling on agitating thoughts, emotionally charged impressions, or highly stimulating mental imagery keeps the nervous system activated even in the absence of external input. Over time, this continuous internal stimulation disturbs sleep, weakens digestion, and reduces emotional stability. This observation is made not as a moral judgment, but as a physiological and psychological insight into how the human system responds to sustained excitation.

When Stimulation Becomes Stress

The central issue, Āyurveda explains, is not sensory experience itself. Seeing, hearing, enjoyment, imagination, and creativity are natural aspects of human life. The problem arises when stimulation becomes excessive, constant, or disconnected from the body's capacity to process it. When the senses are continuously pulled outward – by screens, sounds, images, and thoughts – the body is forced into a state of constant adjustment. Gradually, this effort of adaptation transforms into stress, and stress becomes the soil in which disease grows. Caraka Saṃhitā explains:

शरीरं सत्त्वसंज्ञं च व्याधीनामाश्रयो मतः ।
तथा सुखानां योगस्तु सुखानां कारणं समः ॥

--- चरकसंहिता सूत्रस्थान (१.५५)

The body and mind constitute the substrata of diseases and happiness (i.e., positive health). Balanced utilisation of time, mental faculties, and objects of the sense organs is the cause of happiness.

Food offers a clear parallel. Modern life has reduced eating to fuel intake – quick meals, distracted meals, meals eaten while scrolling or working. Āyurveda does not see food merely as calories or nutrients. Eating is a sensory act involving taste, smell, texture, timing, quantity, and attention. Even nutritious food, when consumed with an overstimulated or distracted mind, can weaken digestion. Over time, imbalance develops not because the food is harmful, but because the sensory relationship with food has been disturbed.

The environment further amplifies this effect. Artificial lighting, irregular schedules, processed foods, constant digital engagement, and sensory noise interfere with the body's natural rhythms. Āyurveda emphasizes that when daily living repeatedly pulls us away from natural cycles – day and night, activity and rest, hunger and digestion – the body initially compensates silently. Eventually, this compensation expresses itself as fatigue, imbalance, and disease.

One of the key insights from the Āyurveda you may heard me talk is that disease does not suddenly “attack” the body (No worries, we'll talk about it later as well!). It is gradually constructed through patterns of perception, sensory exposure, mental engagement, and habitual response. The senses shape perception, perception shapes thought, thought shapes behaviour, and behaviour shapes health. Disease, therefore, is often not an external invasion but a slow outcome of repeated patterns of everyday living.

A Different Way of Living

Āyurveda's response to this understanding is not withdrawal from the world or denial of sensory experience. It does not advocate extreme restraint. Instead, it calls for appropriate use of the senses-eating in ways that support digestion, allowing adequate sleep, creating periods of sensory quiet, and becoming aware of how stimulation affects clarity, energy, and emotional balance. These practices are not medical treatments in the conventional sense, yet they form the foundation of prevention and long-term health.

For students living in fast-paced, screen-dominated, performance-driven environments, this perspective is especially relevant. Āyurveda gently reminds us that the human system is not designed for continuous stimulation without recovery-whether that stimulation comes through visual scenes, sounds, digital media, or persistent mental engagement. Health depends not only on what we consume, but on how much, how often, and in what state of awareness we consume it.

Before the next lecture, observe an ordinary day of your life. Notice how often your senses are engaged: externally through sights and sounds, and internally through thoughts and mental imagery. Notice whether there is any space for genuine rest. Ask yourself a simple question: *If your body and mind could speak clearly, would they say they are being nourished properly - or constantly overstimulated?* Keep that answer to yourself.